



Don't swim in the ocean!

Swimming in the ocean changes the skin microbiome and this can cause infections. <https://digit.in/july19-28>



Freshwater under the Atlantic

A study found that a massive freshwater sea of sorts is buried under the Atlantic Ocean. <https://digit.in/july19-29>

4,000 years ago, a species of termites called *Syntermes dirus* started building a network of tunnels in what is now northeastern Brazil. The waste material from the network of tunnels was ejected into mounds. About 3,500 years ago, work started on the pyramid complex at Giza. The pyramids became known as one of the seven wonders of the world. The dynastic period of ancient Egypt ended with the death of Cleopatra around 30 BC. The termites

are still building the mounds, and have excavated ten cubic kilometers of soil. That is enough to build the pyramid complex at Giza 4,000 times over. The material is distributed in 200 million mounds, over 230,000 square kilometers, which is more than the area covered by Great Britain. The mounds can be seen in satellite photos and Google Earth. The locals knew about the mounds, and referred to them as “murundus”. However, the mounds escaped any serious study. Despite their size and number, they have gone

unnoticed by the scientific community for all of history. The mounds are usually hidden from view because of the deciduous, thorny forests in the area. The type of vegetation is known as caatinga, and is unique to Brazil. As the soil is low in nutrients and acidic, it is not suitable for agriculture. As a result, the mounds were largely undisturbed by human activity for thousands of years. It was only at the end of 2018, that a group of researchers first described these massive termite mounds of Brazil in the journal *Current Biology*.

The Termite Mounds of Brazil

A monumental bioengineering effort by insects

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The fields of
termite mounds

Credit: Roy Funch